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Brand scandals within a corporate social responsibility partnership: asymmetrical effects on for-profit and non-profit brands

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ABSTRACT

This research explores the effects of a brand scandal that affects a for-profit brand collaborating with a non-profit organisation. Two experimental studies demonstrated that the effects on the for-profit brand were driven by the domain of the partnership and the crisis, while the effects on the non-profit brand were not. A crisis in the same domain as the partnership had stronger effects on the for-profit brand (intention to buy and negative word of mouth). These effects are mediated by perceptions of brand hypocrisy and a decrease in for-profit brand equity. The non-profit brand is equally hurt by the for-profit brand crisis, regardless of the partnership-crisis consistency.

Our results indicate a strong asymmetry: the non-profit brand, despite its innocence, is more vulnerable than the guilty for-profit brand.

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Corporate social responsibility; brand crisis; brand equity; brand hypocrisy; mediation model

Introduction

Since 2015, H&M customers worldwide have been invited to join different charity programmes in partnership with UNICEF. Every time a customer purchases a gift card, H&M donates 5% of the total gift card amount to UNICEF to support specific childhood development programmes in developing countries.[1] However, H&M has recently been widely accused of racism because of an image that appeared in its online store that portrayed a Black child model wearing a sweatshirt with the text 'coolest monkey in the jungle'. The image was widely criticised for its reference to a monkey, an animal that has long featured in anti-Black racial and ethnic slurs, and H&M has been overwhelmed by the resulting serious reputational crisis.[2] UNICEF has never distanced itself from H&M in response to this incident, appearing to overlook the plausible negative effects of this crisis on its own reputational assets. To date, there has been no investigation on brand scandals parallel to ethical and responsible practices.

Ethical and responsible practices are becoming increasingly common brand strategies adopted by companies all over the world (Wymer & Sargeant, 2006). One potential means of rapidly positioning a company as ethically and socially responsible is to manage

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partnerships with non-profit organisations in the form of cause-related marketing (CRM) programmes (Brønn & Vrioni, 2001; Kotler & Lee, 2005). CRM involves an alliance between a for-profit brand and a charitable organisation in order to realise a wide range of activities, such as offering products whose proceeds are partially donated to humanitarian programmes, devoting a percentage of company sales to a social issue or developing a communication campaign with a non-profit organisation (Boenigk & Schuchardt, 2013). CRM can lead companies to appear virtuous by highlighting their support of socially desirable goals (Kotler & Lee, 2005; Vanhamme et al., 2015). Existing research has examined the main effects of CRM programmes on intentions to purchase a brand's products (Chang, 2008; Folse et al., 2010), actual product choice (Chang & Cheng, 2015), consumer willingness to pay (Koschate-Fischer, Diamantopoulos et al., 2012) and brand attitude (Polonsky & MacDonald, 2000). Moreover, previous studies (J. E. Kim & Johnson, 2013; Strahilevitz, 1999) have shown that some factors – such as personal cause affinity (Arora & Henderson, 2007), emotional involvement (Baghi et al., 2009), fit between cause and product (Gupta & Pirsch, 2006) and product category (Baghi & Antoetti, 2017) – mediate positive responses to CRM, as they influence the extent to which consumers perceive a link between the product and the social cause (for a review, see Lafferty et al., 2016).

On the other hand, many studies have argued that consumers have become more suspicious of the motives behind companies' support for a cause, which can discredit both the partnership and the company (Anuar & Mohamad, 2012). Scepticism of CRM motives may lead consumers to question whether a company's support of a social cause is designed to benefit the social cause itself out of sincere social concern or, on the contrary, to benefit the firm (Y. J. Kim & Lee, 2009; Webb & Mohr, 1998).

Technically, CRM is a co-branding activity (Hoeffler & Keller, 2002): it is developed by two entities that remain reciprocally independent but join their efforts and image to increase their visibility in a specific domain (Baghi & Gabrielli, 2013, 2018). Each entity contributes its specific competences and experience, adding value to the joint programme. When two brands promote their alliance in a CRM programme, they tend to become associated with one another in the minds of consumers, creating a link between the two brand nodes. Keller (1993) called this occurrence a secondary association that leads consumers to transfer information about one brand in the alliance to the other. The spillover effect describes the phenomenon that occurs when consumers transfer information and opinions from one brand to its partner (Simonin & Ruth, 1998), in the process revising their previous attitudes or behaviours towards both brands. It also refers to the phenomenon in which an event influences beliefs about attributes and entities not directly associated with the event itself (Ahluwalia et al., 2001). Most of the literature on CRM as a corporate social responsibility (CSR) partnership has focused only on for-profit entities, leaving the influence on non-profit brands partially unexplored (Michel & Rieunier, 2012). However, it is plausible that, in a CRM co-branding alliance, both the non-profit and the for-profit brand may be exposed to positive or negative spillover effects due to their alliance. This transfer of association may be caused by positive or negative information or signals about one of the two partners in the alliance, such as a brand's irresponsible behaviour or misconduct (Swaminathan & Reddy, 2004; Votolato & Unnava, 2006). In this case, the benefits of CRM co-branding may be tempered by situations in which one of the brands receives negative publicity (Votolato & Unnava, 2006).

Brand crises are highly negative and unexpected events (Dawar & Lei, 2009) that can threaten a company's existence. These scandals often undermine a brand's perceived ability to deliver expected benefits and weaken brand equity, affecting consumer attitudes and future purchases (Ahluwalia et al., 2000). Brand crises can be of different types. For example, crises can be intentional or unintentional depending on perceived controllability – that is, whether the brand is perceived as deliberately committing violations (Coombs & Holladay, 1996). Furthermore, brand crises can be performance related – involving defective or harmful products and reducing a brand's perceived ability to deliver functional benefits – or values related, wherein ethical issues surrounding the values espoused by the brand are questioned (Dutta & Pullig, 2011). Consistent with signalling theory (Spence, 1974), crises can embody signals of the brand's 'bad' character. As signals, crises can call the credibility of the brand into question and ultimately influence consumers' attitudes and behaviour towards the brand (Connelly et al., 2011), depending on their personal involvement with the crisis issue (Trump, 2014). As brands in an alliance share meaning and associations, crises might affect the culpable brand individually but also the partner brand. Drawing on spillover theory, we posit that crises function as negative associations that could motivate consumers to question not only the credibility of the culpable brand but also that of the partner in the alliance due to negative signals provoked by the scandal.

A key question is whether a brand crisis can influence consumer perceptions of the allied brand(s). In this area, the extant evidence is related to companies (manufacturers or service providers) or product brands, outside the boundaries of the co-branding partners (i.e. effects on competitors and the entire industry; Trump & Newman, 2017). Few studies have investigated the effects of a brand crisis within an alliance involving a different entity akin to a brand (see Table 1 for a summary of relevant studies on crises in alliance contexts). There is no research examining the impact of a crisis within a CRM co-branding alliance, despite several noteworthy real-world examples, of which the above-mentioned scandal of H&M during its alliance with UNICEF is only one. In 2014, the popular ridesharing service Uber announced its 'Ride for a Cause' charity initiative, in which it would donate 1 USD to one of five charities for every ride taken in a given day.[3] However, after 4 weeks, the company was hit by a scandal describing a plan to dig up dirt on immoral practices, from sexual violence to privacy violations.[4] Walmart, despite its philanthropic approach with regard to the Walmart Foundation,[5] has been accused by the International Forum on Workers' Rights of using slave labour in Bangladesh and China.[6] Burberry collaborates with several non-profit organisations (such as Wide Rainbow to promote education and performing arts in low-income areas of the US and the International Youth Foundation to promote entrepreneurship and leadership among youth),[7] but has also been accused by the New York Times of using child labour in its factories. These examples demonstrate the importance of the need to investigate the effects of a scandal involving a company engaged in a CRM co-branding activity with a non-profit organisation.

The present study aims to fill this gap and to investigate the effects of negative information about misconduct on the part of the for-profit partner in a CRM alliance on consumers' responses towards both partners. We also consider the consistency of the misbehaviour with the scope of the CRM alliance – in other words, whether it took place in

Table 1. Key empirical studies on crises in alliance contexts.

Study	Research context	Dependent variable(s)	Key findings
Votolato and Unnava (2006)	Brand–spokesperson alliances	• Attitudes towards the host and partner brand	• Moral crises more detrimental in a spokesperson alliance • Negative spillover to host brand
Carrillat et al. (2013)	Celebrity endorsement scandal	• Brand attitude • Purchase intentions	• Post-crisis brand evaluations more positive when a celebrity admits responsibility
Carrillat et al. (2014)	Celebrity endorsement scandal	• Attitudes towards brand and direct competitor	• Scandals related to the endorser lower attitudes towards the endorsed brand and competitor brands, especially those involving personal crises
Thomas and Fowler (2016)	Impact of defective product crisis on celebrity evaluation	• Attitudes towards celebrity	• Excuses and repentance mitigate negative celebrity evaluations • Ingratiation does not mitigate negative celebrity evaluations
Singh et al. (2020)	Impact of crisis types and response strategies on corporate image of both brands involved in an alliance	• Corporate image • Brand alliance attitude • Purchase intentions	• Preventable crises detrimental to the image of the culpable ally • Denial response effective for restoring corporate image compared with diminishing or acknowledging/rebuilding responses • Non-culpable partner suffers from crises only indirectly due to negative post-crisis attitudes towards the alliance

the same domain (e.g., pollution in an environmental protection CRM programme) or another domain (e.g., tax avoidance in an environmental protection CRM programme).

The growing adoption of CSR practices mirrors the strong consumer interest in companies' ethical and moral conduct (Brunk, 2012; Brunk & De Boer, 2020; Carrigan & Attalla, 2001). Among other benefits associated with CSR (Kang et al., 2016; Sen & Bhattacharya, 2001), for-profit companies known for being socially responsible can better withstand negative publicity following reputational crises (Gistri et al., 2019; Klein & Dawar, 2004). Intriguingly, there is also evidence that a company being socially responsible improves how individuals react to subsequent information about that company's irresponsible behaviour (Eisingerich et al., 2011; Vanhamme et al., 2015). This perspective argues that CSR offers a *buffer effect* in that it builds goodwill with relevant stakeholders that buffers the damaging impact of negative publicity following crises (Fombrun & Gardberg, 2000; Godfrey, 2005; Peloza, 2006). This evidence, however, contrasts with research on the damaging impact of perceived corporate hypocrisy (Pashupati et al., 2002; Wagner et al., 2009). Companies known for their CSR activities, including CRM, might fall under closer scrutiny because their higher voluntary commitments increase the chances of engaging in inconsistent behaviour (Alicke et al., 2012). When inconsistent information is available and the misconduct is in the same domain as the CSR promises, companies suffer from perceptions of hypocrisy, which can damage reputation (Laurent et al., 2014; Lenz et al., 2017; Wagner et al., 2009). Following this stream of literature, we argue that the effect of negative information about a for-profit brand's misconduct on consumers' responses is more damaging when the brand is accused of a misdeed in the same domain as the CRM programme due to perceptions of hypocrisy.

From the non-profit perspective, we argue that negative spillover may occur but should not be influenced by the consistency between the misdeed and the aim of the alliance. We assume that the negative impact on a non-profit brand due to a partner's misconduct is related to the warmth stereotype of non-profit organisations (J. L. Aaker et al., 2012), regardless of the specific social domain of the misconduct. Moreover, when negative information about an ethical misdeed of the for-profit brand partner is available, the non-profit brand partner suffers reputational damages; however, since it is not deemed culpable or complicit in the unethical behaviour, the domain of the misdeed does not aggravate the negative spillover (Votolato & Unnava, 2006). Consistent with this stream of literature, we assume that consumers' evaluations of and behaviour towards a non-profit brand engaged in a CRM programme with a misbehaving for-profit brand are not affected by the specific domain of the for-profit brand's crisis.

Therefore, we assume an asymmetric effect: the for-profit brand is more strongly affected by its misbehaviour when it is strictly related to the CRM domain, while the non-profit brand is equally exposed to negative spillover from the for-profit brand's misbehaviour, regardless of the specific domain of the moral misconduct.

The contribution of the present study is to analyse this situation considering four important aims: 1) filling the literature gap on the effects of a brand crisis on a CRM co-branding alliance; 2) investigating the effects of this crisis on the for-profit and non-profit brands in parallel; 3) highlighting the process that leads to consumers' behavioural reactions to a brand that has misbehaved and was previously involved in a co-branded CRM programme; and 4) introducing the role of the consistency between the domain of the CRM partnership and the misdeed, especially regarding consumers' responses to the for-profit brand.

To extend the generalisability of our analysis, we tested our hypotheses using fictitious brands (Study 1) and real brands (Study 2). In Study 1, we demonstrated that consistency in the domain of the partnership and the crisis is crucial in determining the perceptions of the for-profit brand's hypocrisy, which have a significant negative impact on brand equity evaluation and intention to buy the brand's products. Study 1 also provides evidence that different domains of for profit misconduct within a moral crisis framework do not result in significantly different evaluations of or behaviours towards the non-profit. Study 2 tests our hypotheses using real brands. The findings confirm the results of Study 1 and extend the investigation of the damaging effects on the for-profit brand of a wider range of negative outcomes, including the intention to spread negative word of mouth regarding the hypocritical for-profit brand. Moreover, Study 2 demonstrates that negative outcomes on the non-profit brand in terms of brand equity and intention to donate are the result of a negative spillover effect from the for-profit partner's behaviour, regardless of the values-related crisis domain. Study 1 and Study 2 corroborate the assumption of an asymmetric effect of the relationship-crisis domain on the for-profit versus the non-profit brand. Finally, we discuss our research findings and their theoretical and managerial implications.

Literature review and research hypotheses

Hoeffler and Keller (2002) confirm that a co-branding strategy is the most advisable way to implement positive CRM activities for both brand partners (Michel & Rieunier, 2012). For example, a for-profit brand could be coupled with a non-profit brand to create a special edition of a product or devote a percentage of its revenues to a non-profit brand in order to realise specific programmes (e.g., Mont Blanc and UNICEF[8]). From a branding perspective, a CRM alliance includes all the elements that connote a co-branding activity (D. A. Aaker, 1996; Helmig et al., 2008). First, the two participants are independent before, during and after the product is offered (Ohlwein & Schiele, 1994). In fact, in a CRM activity, the product or programme results from a collaboration between two partners that operate in a distinct context (one is specialised in the product realisation, whereas the other is focused on social goals). Second, they have different structural characteristics (one is a for-profit company; the other is a non-profit organisation), and third, they are formally independent, as they are not together in a holding or group with a certain degree of affinity (Barone et al., 2007). It is important to stress that in a CRM activity, consumers are aware that the programme or product resulting from the partnership links the for-profit and non-profit brand (Hillyer & Tikoo, 1995; Levin et al., 1996; Rao, 1997).

In fact, CRM activity might be shaped in different ways in co-branding contexts. The co-branding literature (D. A. Aaker, 2004, 2006) defines four forms of co-branding. The first occurs when two master brands are strongly involved in co-designing a product labelled by the two brands together – a very specific example, as the product might be authentically new to the market. The second and third kinds of co-branding occur when one partner hosts the other in one of its products or activities: the partner might contribute as an ingredient brand (second type) – for example, a for-profit brand contributing its competences to a social project – or a differentiator (third type), such as a non-profit brand that contributes its social halo to a commercial product (e.g., the special 'Product Red' edition to fund the fight to end AIDS within various well-known companies' portfolios[9]). The fourth co-branding type is tactical alliances: short-term collaborations between two partners to implement a temporary but impressive initiative (e.g., ad campaign, funding campaign). This is one of the most diffuse forms of CRM, wherein a company uses its privileged market positioning and reputation to stress the importance of a social cause – for example, donating part of its revenue to the cause. Whatever the form of co-branding, a partnership between a for-profit and a non-profit brand implies both advantages and risks linked to the co-branding itself. Indeed, Bower and Grau (2009) demonstrated that a company's explicit presentation of its donations to a non-profit resulted in a perception of non-profit endorsement and an inferred explicit seal of approval by the non-profit, implying co-branding opportunities and threats.

The most important advantage of a co-branding CRM partnership is the opportunity to facilitate the reciprocal transfer of positive associations between the two partners (Hoeffler & Keller, 2002). The major risk is the spillover of negative associations from one partner to the other. This risk is particularly high in the CRM context, as many companies engage in ethical misconduct despite their promises made within the alliance. We refer in particular to scandals defined as values-related (Dutta & Pullig, 2011) or moral crises (Votolato & Unnava, 2006), in contrast to those related to products (Dutta & Pullig, 2011) or competence (Votolato & Unnava, 2006). What happens to a non-profit organisation collaborating with a brand in the event of a values-related partner scandal? The literature on brand crises in the alliance domain has not yet considered the case of a partnership between a for-profit and non-profit brand, and the CRM literature has focused only on the positive effects of such partnerships, mostly considering the for-profit perspective. This research proposes a different perspective, considering the frequent case of a values-related scandal involving a for-profit company after the announcement of its collaboration with a non-profit organisation.

Effects on the non-profit brand: hypotheses

First, we turn our attention to the non-profit partner. As discussed above, a link with a for-profit company is considerable as a co-branding activity. There is a risk of negative spillover in the sense of an event or entity that can influence beliefs about other entities associated with it (Ahluwalia et al., 2001). The marketing literature has produced contrasting results about the spillover effect, and marketplace data show that it is not a stable phenomenon (Simonin & Ruth, 1998; Till & Shimp, 1998; Votolato & Unnava, 2006; Washburn et al., 2000). Keller and Aaker (1992) state that a failed brand extension might harm the parent brand, but Swaminathan and Reddy (2004) produced contrasting results in co-branding within brands with different levels of quality in their product portfolios. The marketing literature generally focuses on partnerships between entities embedded in the same context (i.e. companies collaborating in the production of an innovative product). Votolato and Unnava (2006) conducted an interesting experiment in which they considered two entities of a different nature: a for-profit brand and an endorser. Their focus was on the type of misdeed and the kind of relationship. Votolato and Unnava (2006) demonstrated that a host brand not directly involved in or culpable for a moral scandal is still affected by negative information about the partner, even if the partner is of a different nature. Their study opened the door to a stream of research investigating the spillover effect between partners from different fields, which highlighted the relevance of two elements: consistency and culpability. Votolato and Unnava (2006) grounded their hypothesis in the consistency between the crisis domain and the partner's nature and demonstrated that consistency matters only in the event of the culpability of the host brand. In fact, in their study, within an alliance between a company and a person (endorser), a values-related crisis had worse effects than a competence crisis on the host brand only if the host brand was culpable (i.e. aware of its partner's misbehaviour).

Shifting this consideration to the context of CRM alliances, in the event of moral misbehaviour on the part of a for-profit brand already partnered with a non-profit organisation where the latter is not aware of the former's misconduct, we do not expect a significant effect of the specific crisis domain, as in Votolato and Unnava (2006) experiments. The present study deepens the investigation by analysing degrees of consistency in a moral scandal: an ethical scandal in the same domain as the non-profit organisation and an ethical scandal in a different domain. In light of Votolato and Unnava (2006) study, we expect that the specific domain of the moral scandal will not be relevant in terms of the effects on a host brand (the non-profit) unaware of its partner's misbehaviour. The present research shifts previous research to the CRM context and extends the investigation to include more appropriate cognitive and behavioural co-branding dependent variables. While Votolato and Unnava (2006) investigation was limited to effects on brand attitude, the present study considers a potential negative effect at different levels beyond effects on attitude. In line with the co-branding and spillover literature (Choudhury & Kakati, 2014; Washburn et al., 2000), we assume that company misconduct impacts consumers' general evaluations of the partner and intentions to behave favourably or unfavourably towards it. In particular, we assume a negative effect on the non-profit's customer-based brand equity and intention to donate. We consider customer-based brand equity the more appropriate dependent variable, as it can summarise and comprehend different dimensions of consumer evaluation (Choudhury & Kakati, 2014;

Keller & Sood, 2003; Washburn et al., 2000), and intention to donate as the ultimate behavioural outcome for a non-profit organisation.
Thus, our hypotheses are as follows:

H1a: The domain of the crisis involving the for-profit brand (consistent vs inconsistent with respect to partnership domain) does not exert any significantly different effect on the non-profit partner's brand equity.

H1b: The domain of the crisis involving the for-profit brand (consistent vs inconsistent with respect to partnership domain) does not exert any significantly different effect on consumers' intentions to donate to the non-profit partner.

Effects on the for-profit brand: hypotheses

The literature has extensively investigated the effects of negative information about a brand's conduct on consumers' reactions (Ahluwalia et al., 2000; Trump, 2014), and scholars have highlighted the negative repercussions on brand equity (Ahluwalia et al., 2000; Dawar & Lei, 2009; Dawar & Pillutla, 2000; Roehm & Tybout, 2006). As scandals are unexpected events that undermine a brand or product's perceived ability to provide expected benefits, they may damage the brand's overall value. Many researchers have demonstrated that damages resulting from a sudden, unexpected negative event may rapidly erode a firm's accumulated intangible assets, such as brand equity (Ahluwalia et al., 2000; Dawar & Lei, 2009; Dawar & Pillutla, 2000; Pullig et al., 2006; Roehm & Tybout, 2006). Corporate crises often result in negative prominence, threatening brand equity and affecting future purchases (Griffin et al., 1991). The negative impact of a corporate crisis on brand equity is a problem for a company, as brand equity represents overall brand value (D. A. Aaker, 1992). In particular, customer-based brand equity is defined as the added value attributed to a product or marketing activity due to the presence of a specific brand name (Keller, 1993, 2002, 2003). Brand equity as a construct can summarise the value that consumers attribute to a brand, and any element that can negatively alter it (e.g., a brand crisis) may be responsible for permanent damage to the brand. Although the negative impact of values-related crises on brand equity has been somewhat explored in the literature, the specific case of a CRM partnership before the crisis implies some other considerations. In particular, some studies on brand crises have stressed that consumers' responses can vary depending on the crisis context and typology due to the specific corporate associations disconfirmed by the scandal (Brown & Dacin, 1997). In a recent work, Jeon and Baeck (2016) investigated how consumers react to brand scandals, demonstrating that the more people are exposed to brand associations related to an issue, the more likely they are to negatively react to a crisis involving this domain. In the present study, we deepen the investigation of the specific domain of values-related crises and demonstrate whether consumers differentiate their reactions within the domain of the crisis on the basis of previous specific CRM brand association exposure. In particular, when a for-profit brand collaborates with a non-profit organisation on a specific programme to achieve a socially relevant goal, this topic becomes very prominent in its brand composition, joining the mental associations expected to be fixed in consumers' minds when thinking about the brand (D. Aaker, 1991; Gill & Dawra, 2010). Making this mental association more prominent implies that this kind of information will be more likely to be noticed by consumers (Johnston & Hewstone, 1992; Queller & Smith, 2002). New information, such as a brand crisis, is first compared to previous beliefs about the brand entity. If it is congruent, it is categorised within the same informational node, thereby altering previous beliefs; this means that, if the new information is pertinent but contradicts previous beliefs, people tend to take it into consideration, negatively revising their previous beliefs. On the contrary, if the new information is not pertinent, it constitutes a new mental category and thus a different informational node. This theoretical model has been widely adopted by marketing researchers to branding topics (Boush & Loken, 1991; Loken & John, 1993; Weber & Crocker, 1983).

Applying this theory to the specific topic of a crisis after a CRM partnership, it becomes particularly relevant whether the scandal is related to previous beliefs about the brand (i.e. the scandal is in the same domain as the partnership) or is in another domain. We expect that, when the partnership domain and crisis domain are consistent, the scandal information will disconfirm previous brand associations established through the CRM partnership and consumers will revise their opinions of the faulty brand. For this reason, we hypothesise that a crisis involving the topic at the heart of the partnership with the non-profit organisation will have more negative effects on the for-profit brand than a crisis involving a topic not directly related to any co-branding programme by the same company. In the former scenario, the information about the scandal contradicts consumers' previous beliefs and shows that the company is hypocritical. This assumption is consistent with research on the damaging impact of perceived corporate hypocrisy (Pashupati et al., 2002; Wagner et al., 2009). Companies known for their CSR activities might be more closely scrutinised because their higher voluntary commitments increase the chances of inconsistent behaviour (Alicke et al., 2012). When information about misbehaviour in the same domain as the CSR promises is available, companies suffer from perceptions of hypocrisy, which can damage the organisation (Laurent et al., 2014; Lenz et al., 2017; Wagner et al., 2009) and affect consumer intentions to retaliate against the company. This *hypocrisy effect* perspective suggests that a brand involved in a CRM alliance and confronted with a scandal in the same domain as the partnership faces a double condemnation for both the irresponsible behaviour and the perceptions of hypocrisy (Laurent et al., 2014). Following this stream of research, we assume that perceived company hypocrisy aggravates the negative impact of a scandal in the same domain as the CRM engagement on consumers' perceived for-profit brand equity.

H2a: Crisis domain (same vs different with respect to partnership domain) influences for-profit perceived hypocrisy. In particular, when the crisis and partnership domains are consistent, there is a greater positive impact on perceived brand hypocrisy, in comparison with the absence of consistency.

H2b: The more hypocritical the for-profit brand is considered to be, the lower its perceived brand equity.

In other words, brand equity is expected to be hurt by the crisis through the perception of hypocrisy. The attribution of hypocrisy to the for-profit brand is consistent with Weiner's (1980) attribution–affect–intention model, which relates ethical and moral issues

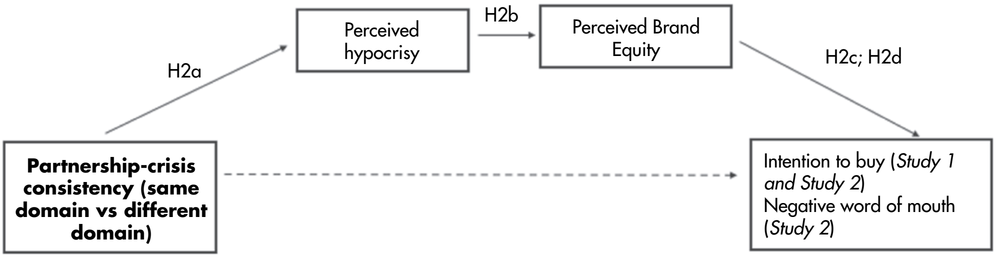

Figure 1. Conceptual model of effects on for-profit brand investigated in Study 1 and Study 2.

to behavioural outcomes. This model explains that, when a negative event occurs due to a specific cause, observers evaluate the information according to their moral beliefs and attributes and develop a desire to punish the subject. That is, negative information may impact individual values and stimulate intentions (Alicke, 2000). The literature on brand scandals demonstrates that the final dependent variable of a scandal is the intention to behave in a certain way towards the brand (Ahluwalia et al., 2000; Frijda, 2000). Several researchers have recognised the relationship between attribution and behavioural outcome – in particular, the ultimate consumer behavioural outcome, namely intention to buy the products offered by the for-profit brand (Folkes, 1984; Jorgensen, 1994; Romani et al., 2013). This intention is strictly linked to the overall value assigned to the brand (i.e. brand equity; Cobb-Walgren et al., 1995; Jalilvand & Samiei, 2012; Senthilnathan, 2012).

To conclude, we hypothesise that the damage to for-profit brand equity caused by a crisis (through perceived hypocrisy) has a significant effect on consumers' intentions to buy the for-profit brand's products.

H2c: A for-profit brand crisis reduces intention to buy the for-profit brand's products through the mediation of perceived hypocrisy and brand equity.

Figure 1 summarises the conceptual model investigated in the present study.

Study 1: research method and measures

A sample of 160 Italian consumers (61.3% male; mean age 32 years) took part in an online experiment. Participants were recruited on Prolific Academic. Respondents were on average interested in the ethical issues related to the study (single sample *t*-test respected to middle point of scale = 4; $p > .05$) and did not differ significantly in terms of personal involvement on these ethical issues across the manipulation sets (independent *t*-test $p > .05$). We conducted an experimental analysis with the aim of improving internal validity by allowing for tight control of the study setting (Schendler & Hofer, 1979). The control inherent in experimental studies increases the ability to test causal hypotheses (J. H. Kim & Jang, 2014). However, the experimental design suffers for low realism in inducing potential scepticism. To overcome this issue, researchers can use realistic representations (e.g., newspaper articles, advertisements, consumer reviews). Hypothetical scenarios are largely used in marketing research on failures to depict realistic scandals (Baghi & Gabrielli, 2021; Dutta & Pullig, 2011; Wang, 2016; Yuan et al., 2016). The present study used a magazine ad to present the CRM activity (in line with Bower & Grau, 2009) and a newspaper article to announce the crisis. Moreover, we checked for co-branding perceptions, scandal credibility and scandal severity within respondents. We conducted a between-subjects experiment with one factor (high crisis–partnership consistency vs low crisis–partnership consistency). At the beginning of the questionnaire, we presented the description of a CRM collaboration between a fictitious company engaged in apparel production, Toscati Moda, and a fictitious non-profit organisation engaged in protecting animals, Unione Diritti Animali (UDA). Participants were told that Toscati Moda had engaged in a funding campaign wherein, for one year, it would donate a percentage of its revenues to UDA for an animal protection programme. The initiative was presented in the form of a fictitious ad published in a fashion magazine. This description of a CRM programme is comparable to the fourth co-branding typology: a tactical alliance. It is generally interpreted as a co-branding activity, despite its transaction-based nature, because two brands are presented simultaneously to consumers (Simonin & Ruth, 1998) and their alliance is based on a CSR foundation. Generally, consumers are very sensitive to the percentage of donations, but not to whether that percentage is of price or profits (Olsen et al., 2003); moreover, they may not fully understand campaign deadlines (Grau et al., 2007). We selected this kind of CRM because it is one of the most recurring within CRM activities and is associated with the lowest degree of commitment between the two partners. We thus supposed that this would be the most adverse scenario for revealing a negative effect and therefore the most suitable for testing our hypothesis.

Both brands were fictitious, but their names directly referred to their core activity: Toscati Moda (Toscati Fashion) referenced fashion, while UDA (Unione per i Diritti degli Animali-Union for Animal Rights) referenced animal rights. After providing this information, we asked respondents to answer some questions about the alliance through four semantic differentials (Simonin & Ruth, 1998) to check whether they evaluated the partnership as plausible, meaningful and substantial. Respondents confirmed that they had assimilated the information about the partnership and considered it equally and highly meaningful ($M_{\text{no-fit set}} = 4.90$ vs $M_{\text{fit set}} = 5.15$; t-test $p > .05$). They were then presented with a fictitious newspaper article about a case of brand misconduct by the for-profit organisation Toscati Moda subsequent to the collaboration. We manipulated the partnership–crisis consistency. In the high-consistency condition, the for-profit brand was accused of using pelt inserts in its apparel products, while in the low-consistency condition, the for-profit company was accused of breaking hygiene rules in its buildings. We performed manipulation checks on partnership–crisis consistency (5 items scored on a 7-point Likert scale; Lee et al., 2012). Scores were in line with scenario manipulations ($M_{\text{partn.-crisis fit within no-consistency set}} = 3.32$ vs $M_{\text{partn.-crisis fit within consistency set}} = 3.86$; t-test $p < .05$). We also checked crisis severity (Antonetti & Maklan, 2016) and credibility (Newell & Goldsmith, 2001). Despite the different degrees of consistency with the partnership, the two crises were perceived as equally credible ($M_{\text{credib. within no-consistency set}} = 3.92$ vs $M_{\text{credib. within consistency set}} = 4.20$; t-test $p > .05$) and equally severe ($M_{\text{sev. within no-consistency set}} = 4.89$ vs $M_{\text{sev. within consistency set}} = 5.24$; t-test $p > .05$). These checks legitimate the adequacy of the two experimental scenarios.

After reading the newspaper article, participants were asked to rate the hypothesised moderators: perceived for-profit brand hypocrisy (5 items scored on a 7-point Likert scale; Wagner et al., 2009), for-profit brand equity and non-profit brand equity (17 items scored on a 7-point Likert scale; Baghi & Gabrielli, 2019). Next, the hypothesised dependent variable was rated: respondents were asked to indicate their intentions to buy the brand's products in the future (2 items scored on a 7-point Likert scale; Grewal et al., 1998) and to donate to the non-profit organisation (2 items scored on a 7-point Likert scale; Savary et al., 2015). At the end of the questionnaire, we asked for some sociodemographic sample characteristics.

Study 1: analysis and results

Measures

We checked the reliability of the questionnaire's scales: for-profit brand hypocrisy (AVE = .73; CR = .82; α = .89), for-profit brand equity (AVE = .88; CR = .94; α = .89), non-profit brand equity (AVE = .78; CR = .84; α = .95), for-profit intention to buy (α = .86) and non-profit intention to donate (α = .92). Discriminant validity was supported, as the Fornell–Larcker criterion was met for all constructs and loadings were always higher than cross-loadings (Hair et al., 2011).

Study 1: effects on non-profit brand

Analysis showed that the independent variable of partnership–crisis fit did not induce any differential effect on the non-profit brand. We performed two distinct analyses to investigate the eventual negative effects on two dependent variables related to the non-profit brand: its brand equity and consumers' intentions to donate to the non-profit organisation.

In particular, the *t*-test did not show any significant effect of partnership–crisis fit on non-profit brand equity. Participants did not attribute any significantly lower score to the non-profit's brand equity in the presence of the same partnership–crisis domain ($M_{\text{non-profit brand equity}} = 3.90$) than in a different partnership–crisis domain ($M_{\text{non-profit brand equity}} = 3.86$; *t*-test $p > .05$).

Moreover, our analysis did not show any significant effect of partnership–crisis domain on consumers' intentions to donate to the non-profit. Participants were not differently prone to donate to a non-profit organisation linked to a faulty for-profit brand in the presence of a scandal consistent with the non-profit's aim ($M_{\text{wtd}} = 2.87$) than in the absence of any consistency between the scandal and the aim of the non-profit ($M_{\text{wtd}} = 2.74$; *t*-test $p > .05$). The absence of any differential effect of partnership–crisis consistency on either non-profit brand equity or intention to donate fully supports H1a and H1b.

Study 1: effects on for-profit brand

Brand hypocrisy

Our analysis showed a main and positive effect of partnership–crisis consistency on perceived for-profit brand hypocrisy. Participants showed a higher perception of hypocrisy of the for-profit brand in the presence of partnership–crisis consistency ($M_{\text{hypocrisy}} = 5.11$) than in its absence ($M_{\text{hypocrisy}} = 4.68$; *t*-test $p < .05$).

Brand equity

Our analysis did not show any main negative effect of partnership–crisis fit on for-profit brand equity (see Table 2). Participants did not show a different level of perceived for-profit brand equity in the presence of partnership–crisis consistency (M_{BE} = 2.94) compared with an absence of partnership–crisis consistency (M_{BE} = 3.02; *t*-test $p > .05$). Therefore, the impact of partnership–crisis consistency on brand equity is not direct but is rather mediated by perceived brand hypocrisy (see further results).

Intention to buy

Our analysis showed a main negative effect of partnership–crisis consistency on intention to buy the for-profit brand's products. Participants showed lower intentions to buy in the presence of partnership–crisis consistency (M_{wtb} = 1.67) than in its absence (M_{wtb} = 2.03; *t*-test $p < .05$).

To test H2a, H2b and H2c, we conducted a mediation analysis using PROCESS model 6 (Hayes, 2012; Muller et al., 2005) with 10,000 bootstrap estimation resamples and 95% confidence intervals to verify the expectation that partnership–crisis consistency would negatively impact intention to buy the for-profit brand's products through two mediators: perceived brand hypocrisy (positively linked) and for-profit brand equity (negatively linked). The independent variable (partnership–crisis consistency) was coded −1 (absence of partnership–crisis consistency) or +1 (presence of partnership–crisis consistency). The analysis was conducted on a sample of 160 between-subjects evaluations. The mean of all items for each construct was used in the analysis after checking scale reliability.

The presence of a crisis in the same domain as the partnership did not have any negative direct effect on the intention to buy the for-profit brand's products, while the effect was sequentially mediated by perceived hypocrisy and for-profit brand equity (see Table 3 for each path coefficient estimation). Partnership–crisis domain consistency increased perceived hypocrisy, which reduced brand equity and intention to buy the faulty brand.

All path coefficients in the model were consistent with the hypotheses. The hypothesised mediation model was supported (indirect effect of partnership–crisis consistency on intention to buy through the sequential mediation of perceived hypocrisy and brand

Table 2. Study 1 descriptive statistics.

		Non-profit brand			For-profit brand		
Dependent variables		Same partnership–crisis domain	Different partnership–crisis domain	*Sig.*	Same partnership–crisis domain	Different partnership–crisis domain	*Sig.*
Perceived hypocrisy	Mean	–	–	–	5.11*	4.68*	.011
	SD	–	–		*1.08*	*1.03*	
Perceived brand equity	Mean	3.91	3.86	.832	2.94	3.02	.658
	SD	*1.36*	*1.37*		*1.01*	*1.20*	
Intention to buy/ donate	Mean	2.87	2.74	.605	1.67*	2.03*	.045
	SD	*1.70*	*1.36*		*1.08*	*1.20*	

** indicates $p < .001$; * indicates $p < .05$

Table 3. Study 1 mediation model for intention to buy for-profit brand's products with partnership–crisis consistency comparison (same vs different domain).

	Unstandardised coefficient	*t*-value	LLCI	ULCI
Partnership–crisis consistency (X) → for-profit brand hypocrisy (M1)	.22	2.56*	.05	.38
For-profit brand hypocrisy (M1)→ for-profit brand equity (M2)	−.34	−4.35	−.49	−.19
For-profit brand equity (M2) → intention to buy for-profit brand's products (Y)	.39	5.36***	.25	.53
Partnership–crisis consistency (X) → intention to buy for-profit brand's products (Y)	−.10	−1.26	−.25	.06
R^2 = 33%, $F(3, 156) = 25.60$, $p < .001$				

Legend: partnership–crisis fit (X) = independent variable; intention to buy (Y) = dependent variable; for-profit brand hypocrisy (M1) and for-profit brand equity (M2) = mediators; LLCI and ULCI = lower-level and upper-level confidence intervals, respectively; all computations used 5,000 bootstrap samples to generate 95% bias-corrected bootstrap confidence intervals; * indicates $p < .05$, ** indicates $p < .01$, *** indicates $p < .001$.

equity = −.03; LLCI = −.06; ULCI = −.01). H2a and H2b are supported, and the overall mediation model with regard to intention to buy the for-profit brand's products was confirmed (H2c).

Study 2: literature review and research hypotheses

The results of Study 1 corroborated our hypothesis that a values-related crisis affecting a for-profit brand previously involved in a CRM activity with a non-profit brand does not have differential effects on the non-profit in the event of a crisis in the same versus a different moral domain as the partnership domain. In contrast, the for-profit brand is affected differently according to the crisis domain: the presence of crisis–partnership consistency induces a significant perception of brand hypocrisy, which negatively affects for-profit brand equity and, in turn, consumers' intentions to buy products offered by the for-profit brand.

After investigating fictitious brands, we developed another study using real brands. This step intended to verify the robustness of the findings of Study 1 and clarify those results, deepening the analysis of the dependent variables in comparison with their pre-crisis average values and extending the analysis to one added dependent variable. The use of real brands allowed us to detect whether the strong effects of a brand scandal after the announcement of a CRM collaboration were resistant to previous beliefs about the brands. The marketing literature describes brand equity as an evolving entity; consumers are always prone to revising their mental associations with a brand and thus to adapting their evaluations of and behaviours towards a brand. For this reason, we expected to observe the same effects even with real, well-known brands. In branding alliance investigations, counterchecking results with real brands is critical to analyse genuine brand associations, as highly familiar brands generally have well-established, accessible and stable prior associations (Simonin & Ruth, 1998). Extending our research to real brands enabled us not only to comprehend whether the effects of the crisis domain were different according to the presence or absence of consistency with the partnership (as for Study 1) but also to compare these effects with prior levels of for-profit and non-profit dependent variables, in the absence of any brand crisis. This is particularly relevant for the non-profit brand. Previous research (Votolato & Unnava, 2006) referred to the spillover effect but did not measure dependent variables in a control set without a crisis. In the second stage, the present study investigated the spillover effect on the non-profit brand, including a control set without any crisis. This condition enabled us to disentangle a relevant topic: does the insignificant effect of partnership–crisis consistency that emerged in Study 1 mean that there is a homogeneous spillover effect or that there is no spillover effect?

Previous research has demonstrated that, for brand extensions and brand alliances, the spillover effect is based on expectations fed by previous experiences and beliefs related to brands (Loken & John, 1993; Simonin & Ruth, 1998). A recent theoretical contribution on brand crises points out that a crisis might have an exogenous source. In particular, Whitler et al. (2021) defined brand infection as an unexpected event that damages a brand through no fault of the focal brand other than its proximity to or shared associations with the transgressing brand. The transfer of negative impact from the transgressing brand to other proximal and/or associated brands is a brand-to-brand damage transfer comparable to a spillover effect. It occurs, for example, from a faulty brand to a competing brand within the same industry, or in any other case of a direct link from the faulty brand to another brand. In the absence of any link, it is an environmental event-to-brand process of damage (e.g., COVID-19). Bower and Grau (2009) demonstrated that the link between the for-profit and non-profit brand is established in consumers' minds beginning with one partner's explicit announcement of the initiative (for example, through an ad). From this moment on, a signal is established and consumers will be conditioned by this information, despite the two partners' different industry scopes (Decker & Baade, 2016). In particular, when one partner is a non-profit, the partnership is likely to be more effective if it is nurtured over time but can also be conveyed through only a sporadic single pairing (Stuart et al., 1987; Till & Nowak, 2000). Accordingly, for-profit brand scandals may provoke a brand infection rather than a brand contamination. A recent investigation of spillover effects in brand infection across different fields (Fan et al., 2019) suggest that expectations are generally based on social norms and standards and that consumers usually automatically refer to stereotypes. The authors focused on warmth versus competence stereotypes, applying them to a brand scandal that occurred in companies originating in countries with high-competence versus high-warmth national stereotypes. The authors demonstrated an interaction between the scandal domain and the country stereotype in provoking damage transfer from the faulty brand to the entire country, conceptually linked by the country-of-origin effect. The country was not directly involved in the crisis but was perceptually 'next to' the brand via the link with a specific trait associated with it (competence or warmth). Within CRM activity, the trait that constitutes the link between the for-profit and the non-profit brand is warmth: non-profit organisations are stereotyped as warm (J. Aaker et al., 2010). We therefore expect that any moral scandal that directly or indirectly involves non-profit organisations (as with the country indirectly involved in the brand scandal in previous research (Fan et al., 2019) violates consumers' expectations based on the non-profit organisation's warmth stereotype, despite the specific domain of warmth or moral transgression. Thus, in Study 2, we expected to observe a significant spillover effect on the non-profit brand but anticipated that this negative effect would occur regardless of the specific crisis domain (consistent with Study 1), as any moral crisis contrasts with the non-profit's warmth stereotype.

H1c: The for-profit brand crisis exerts a negative spillover effect on the non-profit's brand equity, regardless of the crisis–partnership domain.

H1d: The for-profit brand crisis exerts a negative spillover effect on consumers' intentions to donate to the non-profit brand, regardless of the crisis–partnership domain.

Regarding the for-profit brand, we expected to observe the same causal relations that emerged in Study 1: a significant effect of crisis–partnership domain consistency on intention to purchase the for-profit brand's products, mediated by perceived hypocrisy and brand equity. However, Study 2 expanded the analysis to include another dependent variable: the intention to spread negative word of mouth about the for-profit brand. There is significant evidence that consumers often punish companies for their ethical violations by spreading negative information about the brand (Antonetti & Maklan, 2016; Grappi et al., 2013; Romani et al., 2013). Consumers engage in negative word of mouth out of a desire to correct a perceived injustice of which they disapprove (Bechwati & Morrin, 2003; Grappi et al., 2013). Spreading negative information about the company is also a way to express a general sense of dissatisfaction (Richins, 1983) or to assuage negative emotions by sharing information with others (Choi & La, 2013; Richins, 1983) in order to punish a faulty and hypocritical brand.

In Study 2, we investigated the same theoretical model for real, well-known brands and extended our hypotheses to another dependent variable relevant to well-known brands: the activation of negative word of mouth towards both brands involved in the partnership (for-profit and non-profit).

In summary, for the for-profit brand, the hypotheses in Study 2 are the same as those in Study 1. We included the intention to spread negative word of mouth as another potential negative outcome that could damage both brands involved.

H1e: The for-profit brand crisis (same vs different with respect to partnership domain) exerts a negative spillover effect on consumers' intentions to spread negative word of mouth about the non-profit brand, regardless of the crisis–partnership domain.

H2d: The for-profit brand crisis (same vs different with respect to partnership domain) increases intention to spread negative word of mouth about the for-profit brand through the mediation of perceived hypocrisy and brand equity.

Figure 1 summarises the conceptual model investigated in the present study.

Study 2: research method and measures

A sample of 219 Italian consumers participated in Study 2 (70% female; mean age 38 years). Participants were recruited on Prolific Academic. Respondents were on average interested in the ethical issues related to the study (single sample t-test respect middle point of scale = 4; $p > .05$) and did not differ significantly in terms of personal involvement in these ethical issues across the manipulation sets (independent t-test $p > .05$). We conducted a between-subjects experiment with one factor (high crisis–partnership consistency vs low crisis–partnership consistency vs no crisis). The methods and procedures of Study 2 were similar to those of Study 1, with the addition of the control set to collect evaluations of real brands prior to the crisis. Brand domain and crisis typologies were the same, but we adopted two real, well-known brands.

The choice to replicate the same scenarios in Study 2 was intended to provide comparable results in order to highlight any potential similarities or discrepancies between artificial and real brands, all else being equal. Moreover, due to the presence of already-known brands in Study 2, the presence of a control set (with no crises) was intended to better qualify the negative effects on non-profit brand equity as a spillover effect in order to offer a deeper understanding of Study 1's findings.

We chose apparel brand Zara as the for-profit organisation and WWF – which focuses on animal protection – as the non-profit organisation. Hereafter we will refer to Zara as the for-profit brand (FPB) and to WWF as the non-profit brand (NPB). These two brands were selected based on a pre-test conducted among 82 Italian consumers. They were rated as well-known brands with the same level of brand awareness (Mfor-profit baw = 4.34 vs Mnon-profit baw = 4.27; $p > .05$).

As in Study 1, in Study 2 we first presented the co-branding CRM collaboration between the for-profit brand and non-profit organisation for both the control and the manipulated sets. After presenting this information, we asked respondents to answer some questions about the alliance's meaningfulness through four semantic differentials (Simonin & Ruth, 1998). They were then presented with a fictitious newspaper article about a case of brand misconduct by the for-profit organisation. In the high-consistency condition, FPB was accused of using pelt inserts in its apparel products, while in the low-consistency condition, FPB was accused of breaking hygiene rules in its buildings. In the control condition (no crisis), participants were not presented with the newspaper article about FPB's misconduct. After the scenario description, participants were asked to answer questions about the mediators and dependent variables. Measures were the same as those used in Study 1, with the addition of intention to spread negative word of mouth about the for-profit and non-profit brands as an additional dependent variable (2 items scored on a 7-point Likert scale; Romani et al., 2013).

Study 2: analysis and results

Manipulation checks

A manipulation check confirms the adequacy of the two brands selected: FPB and NPB were confirmed as well-known brands (single-sample *t*-test *M*for-profit baw = 4.28 vs middle point of scale = 4, $p < .05$; single-sample *t*-test *M*no-profit baw = 4.16 vs middle point of scale = 4, $p < .05$) that registered no significantly different levels of brand awareness ($M_{\text{for-profit baw}} = 4.28$ vs $M_{\text{no-profit baw}} = 4.16$; *t*-test $p > .05$).

The partnership was rated as equally plausible, meaningful and substantial in the two manipulation sets ($M_{\text{no-fit set}} = 4.75$ vs $M_{\text{fit set}} = 4.92$; *t*-test $p > .05$). Regarding partnership–crisis consistency, the average score was significantly different between the two manipulation sets, in line with scenario manipulations ($M_{\text{partn.-crisis fit within no-consistency set}} = 2.92$ vs $M_{\text{partn.-crisis fit within consistency set}} = 3.75$; *t*-test $p < .05$), although the two crises were perceived as equally credible ($M_{\text{credib. within no-consistency set}} = 3.88$ vs $M_{\text{credib. within consistency set}} = 4.11$; *t*-test $p > .05$; Newell & Goldsmith, 2001) and equally severe ($M_{\text{sev. within no-consistency set}} = 4.33$

vs $M_{\text{sev. within consistency set}} = 4.40$; t-test $p > .05$; Antonetti & Maklan, 2016). These checks legitimate the adequacy of the two experimental scenarios.

Finally, in order to corroborate the hypothesis based on the warmth stereotype, we measured the average level of warmth (5 items scored on a 7-point Likert scale; Halkias & Diamantopoulos, 2020) for the for-profit and non-profit brands. In line with our expectations, non-profit brand warmth was significantly higher than for-profit (*M*for-profit warmth = 4.38 vs *M*no-profit warmth = 4.97; t-test $p < .05$).

Measures

We checked for the reliability of the questionnaire's scales: for-profit brand hypocrisy (AVE = .83; CR = .85; α = .80), for-profit brand equity (AVE = .89; CR = .93; α = .92), non-profit brand equity (AVE = .78; CR = .84; α = .92), for-profit intention to buy (α = .93), for-profit negative word of mouth (α = .92) and non-profit negative word of mouth (α = .86). Discriminant validity was supported, as the Fornell–Larcker criterion was met for all constructs and loadings were always higher than cross-loadings (Hair et al., 2011).

Study 2: effects on non-profit brand

Our analysis (see Table 4 for descriptive statistics) showed that the independent variable of partnership–crisis consistency induced a spillover effect on non-profit brand equity and that this effect was the same whether or not a crisis was pertinent to the partnership domain.

In particular, MANOVA showed a significant effect of partnership–crisis consistency on non-profit brand equity ($F(1, 216) = 114.82$; $p < .001$). Participants attributed a significantly lower score to non-profit brand equity in the presence of a partner crisis ($M_{\text{BE\_no crisis}} = 5.19$ vs $M_{\text{BE\_same domain}} = 4.17$ vs $M_{\text{BE\_different domain}} = 3.94$). Simple contrasts show no significant difference between a crisis related to the partnership domain and one extraneous to the partnership domain ($p > .05$). H1a is thus supported, as in Study 1. H1c is also supported: the for-profit partner crisis induces a negative spillover effect on non-profit brand equity, regardless of the pertinence of the crisis to the partnership domain.

Moreover, MANOVA showed a significant effect of partnership–crisis consistency on consumers' intentions to donate to the non-profit brand (F(1, 214 = 4.630; $p < .05$). Participants were less prone to donate to a non-profit organisation linked to a faulty for-profit brand ($M_{\text{wtd\_no crisis}} = 3.57$ vs $M_{\text{wtd\_same domain}} = 3.20$ vs $M_{\text{wtd\_other domain}} = 2.79$). In fact, simple contrasts show that willingness to donate is lower in the presence of a partner crisis with respect to the control set, but this negative effect is not significantly different ($M_{\text{wtd\_same domain}} = 3.20$ vs $M_{\text{wtd\_other domain}} = 2.79$; $p > .05$) in the presence of a scandal consistent with the non-profit organisation's aim and in the absence of any consistency between the scandal and the aim of the non-profit organisation. H1b is thus supported, as in Study 1, and H1d is also supported.

Regarding the intention to activate negative word of mouth, the difference in experimental conditions confirmed the pattern that emerged in previous analyses of dependent variables. MANOVA showed a significant effect of the for-profit partner crisis, as the control set registered a lower score than the manipulated sets (F(1, 214 = 2.91; $p < .05$; Mnwom_no crisis = 1.66 vs Mnwom_same domain = 2.07 vs Mnwom_other

Table 4. Study 2 descriptive statistics.

		Non-profit brand				For-profit brand			
Dependent Variables		No crisis	Same partnership–crisis domain	Different partnership–crisis domain	*Sig.*	No crisis	Same partnership–crisis domain	Different partnership–crisis domain	*Sig.*
Perceived hypocrisy	Mean	–	–	–	–	3.74	4.60*	4.27*	.000
	SD	–	–	–	–	*0.74*	*0.89*	*0.84*	
Perceived brand equity	Mean	5.19*	4.17	3.94	.000	4.76*	2.77	2.70	.000
	SD	*1.01*	*0.92*	*0.97*		*0.90*	*1.02*	*0.90*	
Intention to buy/ donate	Mean	3.57*	3.20	2.79	.011	4.53*	3.16	2.92	.000
	SD	*1.73*	*1.42*	*1.43*		*1.54*	*1.57*	*1.61*	
Negative word of mouth	Mean	1.66*	2.07	1.93	.043	2.51*	3.77	3.46	.000
	SD	*0.94*	*1.05*	*1.12*		*1.27*	*1.51*	*1.42*	

** indicates $p < .001$; * indicates $p < .05$

domain = 1.93). Simple contrasts show that partnership–crisis consistency does not exert any significant effect on consumers' intentions to activate negative word of mouth against the non-profit brand ($p > .05$). H1a is therefore supported.

All of the dependent variables referring to the non-profit brand showed the same pattern: as in Study 1, the pertinence of the for-profit crisis to the partnership domain did not matter. However, using real brands in Study 2 enabled us to discover that the average score of dependent variables in the presence of any kind of for-profit brand crisis is systematically lower than the corresponding score pre-crisis (control set). That is, the non-significant effect registered in Study 1 does not mean that the for-profit brand is not responsible for any spillover effect on the non-profit brand. On the contrary, a spillover effect due to the for-profit crisis occurs, but it does not depend on consistency between the crisis and the partnership domain. Moreover, this negative effect is not limited to non-profit brand equity and consumers' intentions to donate to the non-profit brand but also impacts willingness to spread negative word of mouth about the non-profit brand.

Study 2: effects on for-profit brand

Brand hypocrisy

MANOVA showed a main and positive effect of partnership–crisis consistency on perceived for-profit brand hypocrisy ($F(1, 218) = 14.41$; $p < .05$). Even for well-known brands, participants showed a higher perception of hypocrisy of the for-profit brand in the presence of a crisis consistent with the partnership ($M_{\text{hypocrisy}} = 4.60$) than in the absence of partnership–crisis consistency ($M_{\text{hypocrisy}} = 4.27$) or in the absence of any kind of crisis ($M_{\text{hypocrisy}} = 3.74$). Simple contrasts show that a crisis in the same domain as the partnership increases perceived hypocrisy compared with a crisis in a different domain ($p < .05$) or no crisis ($p < .05$). A simple contrast shows a significant difference in the impact on perceived hypocrisy between a same-domain condition and a different-domain condition ($p < .05$) and between a same-domain condition and a no-crisis condition ($p < .05$). There was also a significant difference between a different-domain condition and a no-crisis condition for the same variable ($p < .05$).

Brand equity

MANOVA showed a significant effect of a for-profit brand crisis on perceived brand equity ($F(1, 218) = 114.815$; $p < .001$), but this effect is not related to partnership–crisis consistency. In fact, participants showed a different level of for-profit brand equity in the presence of partnership–crisis in comparison with the control set (i.e. in the absence of any crisis; $M_{\text{BE\_no crisis}} = 4.76$ vs $M_{\text{BE\_same domain}} = 2.77$ vs $M_{\text{BE\_other domain}} = 2.70$), but a simple contrast does not show a significant difference between the two manipulation sets ($p > .05$). There is, however, a significant difference between a different-domain condition and a no-crisis condition for the same variable ($p < .05$) and between a same-domain condition and a no-crisis condition ($p < .05$).

Intention to buy

MANOVA showed a significant effect of partnership–crisis consistency on intention to buy the for-profit brand's products ($M_{\text{wtb\_no crisis}} = 4.53$ vs $M_{\text{wtb\_same domain}} = 3.16$ vs

Table 5. Study 2 mediation model for for-profit brand dependent variables with partnership–crisis fit comparison (presence of fit vs absence of fit).

	Unstandardised coefficient	*t*-value	LLCI	ULCI
Partnership–crisis fit (X) → for-profit brand hypocrisy (M1)	.17	2.22*	.02	.30
For-profit brand hypocrisy (M1)→ for-profit brand equity (M2)	−.33	−3.70	−.51	−.16
For-profit brand equity (M2) → intention to buy for-profit brand (Y1)	.85	7.18***	.62	1.09
Partnership–crisis fit (X) → intention to buy for-profit brand (Y1)	.14	1.25	−.08	.36
R^2 = 35%, $F(3, 139) = 24.88$, $p < .001$				
For-profit brand equity (M2) → negative word of mouth (Y3)	−.33	−2.97***	−.54	−.11
Partnership–crisis fit (X) → negative word of mouth (Y3)	.03	.34	−.17	.24
R^2 = 34%, $F(3, 140) = 23.97$, $p < .001$				

Legend: partnership–crisis fit (X) = independent variable; intention to buy (Y1), intention to boycott (Y2) and intention to activate negative word of mouth (Y3) regarding for-profit brand = dependent variables; for-profit brand hypocrisy (M1) and for-profit brand equity (M2) = mediators; LLCI and ULCI = lower-level and upper-level confidence intervals, respectively; all computations used 5,000 bootstrap samples to generate 95% bias-corrected bootstrap confidence intervals; * indicates $p < .05$, ** indicates $p < .01$, *** indicates $p < .001$.

$M_{\text{wtb\_other domain}}$ = 2.92; F(1, 218 = 22.81; p < .001). A simple contrast does not show a significant difference between a same-domain condition and a different-domain condition (p > .05). There is, however, a significant difference between a different-domain condition and a no-crisis condition for the same variable (p < .05) and between a same-domain condition and a no-crisis condition (p < .05).

Negative word of mouth

MANOVA showed a similar pattern: a for-profit brand crisis induces consumers to activate negative word of mouth ($M_{\text{nwom,\_no crisis}}$ = 2.51 vs $M_{\text{nwom \_same domain}}$ = 3.77 vs $M_{\text{nwom\_other domain}}$ = 3.46; F(1, 219 = 16.41; p < .001). A simple contrast shows that the average score of the no-crisis set is significantly different from the score of the same-domain (p < .05) and different-domain conditions (p < .05). There is, however, no significant difference between a different domain condition and a same-domain condition for the same variable (p > .05). Therefore, the impact of partnership–crisis consistency on the dependent variables is not direct but rather is mediated by perceived brand hypocrisy and brand equity (see mediation model results).

Mediation model: intention to buy for-profit brand's products

Next, we ran a conditional effect analysis using PROCESS model 6 with perceived hypocrisy and brand equity as sequential mediators (Hayes, 2015), consistent with the approach adopted in Study 1. As in Study 1, we hypothesised a significant effect of partnership–crisis consistency on the dependent variables through the mediation of perceived hypocrisy and for-profit brand equity. We performed a distinct analysis for each dependent variable.

The presence of a crisis in the same domain as the partnership (partnership–crisis consistency) does not induce any negative direct effect on the intention to buy the for-profit brand's products, while the effect is mediated by perceived hypocrisy and for-profit brand equity. The hypothesised mediation model is supported with regard to intention to buy the brand's products (indirect effect = −.05; LLCI = −.10; ULCI = −.05) and intention to spread negative word of mouth (indirect effect = .02; LLCI = .00; ULCI = .05). All path coefficients in the model were consistent with H2a and H2b (see Table 5 for each path coefficient estimation). Consistent with Study 1, the hypothesised mediation model is verified for intention to buy (H2c) and intention to spread negative word of mouth (H2d).

Discussion

This research is the first attempt to merge the literature on CRM and brand crises, investigating the effects of a values-related crisis within a CRM framework. Previous studies have focused on co-branding involving for-profit companies. Some sparse literature on brand scandals has considered co-branding between a for-profit company and a different entity (e.g., endorsers, individual brands, suppliers), but non-profit-organisations remain understudied.

Two studies were conducted to understand what happens within a co-branding alliance between a for-profit and a non-profit brand when the former is involved in a brand crisis after the implementation of the partnership. The present research offers a parallel investigation, considering not only the effects on the for-profit brand but also those on the non-profit. The study represents the effects with regard to perceptive (brand hypocrisy), cognitive (brand equity) and behavioural (intention to buy/donate and to spread negative word of mouth) variables. Our analysis focused not only on the perspective of the for-profit brand (which was directly involved in the scandal) but also on the non-profit one (which was not directly involved in the scandal).

The first study adopted fictitious brands in experimental conditions. It was limited to one behavioural dependent variable: the intention to buy the for-profit brand's products or to donate to the non-profit brand. In the second study, the same hypothesised model was applied to well-known brands and was extended to another dependent variable: the intention to activate negative word of mouth against the brands (non-profit and for-profit). The conceptual framework was based on perceived consistency in consumers' mental processes between the partnership domain and the crisis domain, comparing a scenario of a crisis in the same domain as the partnership (presence of partnership–crisis consistency) with a scenario of a crisis in a different domain (absence of partnership–crisis consistency). Results showed that a values-related crisis involving a for-profit brand did not differently affect the non-profit brand partnered with it: consumers' intentions to donate to the non-profit organisation were not statistically different in the event of a partner scandal in the same versus a different domain compared with the partnership.

These results are in line with the co-branding literature (Ahluwalia et al., 2001; Choudhury & Kakati, 2014; Singh et al., 2020), which indicates that partner misconduct can negatively affect a co-brand despite its lack of involvement in the crisis. This research confirms this effect in a context (CRM) that has been unexplored to date. As in Votolato and Unnava (2006), the present study corroborates the existence of the negative crisis effect within a partnership between a company and an entity of a different nature (in Votolato and Unnava, an endorser), confirming that, when the partner is not faulty, this negative effect is unrelated to the partnership–crisis consistency. However, the present study investigates a more specific case of consistency than in Votolato and Unnava (2006) – namely, an intra-type consistency (presence vs absence of consistency within a values-based crisis) rather than an inter-type consistency (performance-related vs values-related crisis) – and extends the perspective to include an holistic dependent variable: brand equity (rather than attitude).

For well-known brands, this homogenous effect is also registered for the intention to spread negative word of mouth. Moreover, for well-known brands, our results allow for the observation that non-profit dependent variables are systematically and significantly lower after the for-profit crisis, regardless of the specific moral crisis domain: in other words, a negative spillover effect on the non-profit brand occurs, regardless of partnership–crisis consistency. This result is in line with the assumption of injury as a result of the warmth stereotype, which has been demonstrated in other contexts (Fan et al., 2019; J. L. Aaker et al., 2012), inducing a negative effect irrespective of the partnership–crisis consistency.

On the contrary, the independent variable (partnership–crisis consistency) has a significant effect on the for-profit brand. A crisis in the same domain as the cause-related partnership induces a stronger effect in terms of perceptions of for-profit brand hypocrisy, which in turn affects for-profit brand equity and the intention to buy the for-profit brand's products. The hypothesised mediation model is confirmed. This result confirms the findings of Jeon and Baeck (2016) in the link between the negative effect of a crisis and the salience of information in consumers' minds and extends this evidence to CRM co-branding activities.

The emerged effects are robust – as Study 2 confirmed Study 1's findings in the context of well-known brands – as well as wide, as the same effects were also registered in Study 2 for the added dependent variable (intention to spread negative word of mouth) in line with the attribution–affect–intention theoretical model (Alicke, 2000).

Theoretical and managerial implications

A partnership with a non-profit brand is a feasible and effective way for a company to implement a CSR brand image, but it entails a certain degree of risk. A moral scandal may occur in the same domain (as described earlier in the cases of H&M and Burberry) or a different domain (as detailed earlier in the case of Uber). In particular, in the event of a scandal involving the same values domain as the partnership, the existence of a previous CSR alliance might work against the for-profit brand. Being seen as a socially responsible brand thanks to an alliance with a non-profit organisation exposes the for-profit brand to the risk of being deemed hypocritical. The shame of being perceived as a brand that is not authentically aware of ethical, social or environmental issues, but rather takes advantage of such concerns for its own image and profit, is an actual risk. An air of greenwashing lingers on those brands and particularly takes shape in the event of a values-related brand crisis.

Moreover, our results show that the risk of hypocrisy is a significant negative effect, as it deteriorates an intangible asset: brand equity. That is, it not only induces a temporary effect on consumers' intentions to punish the brand by refraining from buying its products but implies a revision of consumers' holistic evaluations of the brand in terms of brand equity, as well. Study 2 demonstrated the risk for well-known companies, despite their brand awareness and cause-related practice, as consumers are even prone to actively and consciously involving other people by spreading negative word of mouth about the brand.

From a managerial point of view, a co-branding CRM activity has both upsides and downsides: in the event of honest conduct, it effectively feeds brand value, but in the event of misconduct, it might backfire on the for-profit brand, regardless of the brand's intentions. In the present study, the intentionality of the brand was not manipulated. Thus, one relevant managerial implication for companies is that a co-branding CRM activity must be coupled with strong monitoring of the ethical domain, as the for-profit brand must absolutely prevent even an unintentional scandal (especially in the same domain). Unfortunately, many companies misunderstand these co-branding CRM activities; some of them seem to interpret such programmes as a sort of parachute in case of any misconduct. The results of the present studies demonstrate that CRM programmes are not a way to immunise the brand against negative reactions; on the contrary, the tumble from a higher CSR standpoint could be very violent.

Moreover, the present research reveals that CRM alliances might be very harmful to non-profit brands, as any values-related crisis involving the for-profit brand may have strong negative effects on the non-profit brand. Results showed a dangerous asymmetrical frame: the non-profit brand contributes to the alliance with its warmth but suffers from this stereotype, exposing itself to a strong spillover effect in the event of any misbehaviour by the non-profit partner. In contrast, the for-profit brand is particularly harmed by its misbehaviour only when it is related to the same partnership domain. This has relevant implications for non-profit organisations: for-profit partners are strongly able to jeopardise non-profit organisations, even with misbehaviours extraneous to the alliance. Indeed, as argued by Bower and Grau (2009), if a non-profit is linked to a brand, a consumer may assume that surely it would have performed due diligence, particularly given its expertise and motivation in the social domain.

From a theoretical point of view, this study intended to fill literature gaps in four ways: (1) investigating brand crises in a new context (CRM co-branding); (2) offering a more complete point of observation, investigating the effects on the non-profit organisation as well as on the for-profit brand; (3) deepening the investigation by adopting an intra-type manipulation versus inter-type crisis consistency; and (4) broadening the perspective on the phenomenon by investigating a wider spectrum of dependent variables (brand equity, willingness to buy/donate, negative word of mouth) with respect to the state of the art.

The vulnerability of a non-profit brand to a partner's moral misconduct corroborates the assumption that CRM activities are a particular form of co-branding alliance (as in Bower & Grau, 2009). In addition to confirming the homogeneous effect of different kinds of moral crises outside the non-profit brand's control (as in Votolato & Unnava, 2006), the present study reveals the spillover effect resulting from the contrast between the situation and the non-profit brand's warmth stereotype (as in Fan et al., 2019).

Moreover, the present research deepens the analysis of co-branding CRM activities by adopting a micro-perspective, analysing consistency within one category of crisis (i.e. values-related crises) and introducing for the first time the concept of intra-category pertinence (the presence or absence of consistency between the values-related scandal domain and the partnership domain). This is the first study to investigate crisis consistency within the context of a specific kind of scandal, as opposed to comparing competence-related versus moral scandals. Thus, our results confirm the appropriateness of a mental accounting approach in co-branding investigations. Although consumers are strongly resistant to revising their beliefs, in the event of a for-profit crisis in the same domain as a previous salient partnership, they react by combining this pertinent information with their previous mental associations regarding the brand. That is, the previous alliance establishes new informational nodes in consumers' minds related to the ethical profile of the brand. Paradoxically, this makes the for-profit brand more vulnerable to being hurt by a scandal conflicting with this salient belief.

Finally, the evidence of the present study contributes to the co-branding framework for CRM activities, going beyond previous research by offering a different level of activation investigation. In particular, previous research has focused on a perceptual level (attitude), while the present study included the analysis of effects on a multi-dimensional dependent variable (brand equity) and on different behavioural effects related to the individual (willingness to buy/donate) and to this individual's embeddedness in a reference group (intention to spread negative word of mouth).

Limitations and future directions

This section addresses some limitations of our two studies and suggests related paths for future research. Our first limitation is that our sample is limited to Italian consumers. In light of previous studies, this sample might not favour our results, as Italian consumers belong to an individualistic culture. The literature on brand crises demonstrates that individualistic cultures are less sensitive to values-related crises than performance-related ones (Baghi & Gabrielli, 2019). Therefore, by manipulating a values-related crisis within an individualistic sample, we might have undercut the effect of partnership–crisis consistency. Future research is encouraged to investigate the same issue in a collectivistic culture that is more sensitive to values-related misconduct, where results are likely to be stronger.

Another limitation is linked to the CRM co-branding activity used as a stimulus. We described a tactical co-branding alliance. However, this experimental scenario might not favour our results, as this is the lightest form of co-branding. Future research is encouraged to investigate a for-profit scandal in the context of a stronger form of CRM co-branding (e.g., a co-designed product linked to a social cause). The effects within such a stronger co-branding are likely to be even higher, as the mental association transfer between the two partners might be more intense. Besides employing a different co-branding setting, the manipulation of different crises might be managed as well in order to corroborate the generalisability of our findings.

Finally, our investigation is a first attempt to highlights the effects of brand crisis on several variables. We analysed brand equity as a whole, but future research might investigate the effects on each component of this relevant intangible asset (Keller, 1993, 2002, 2003): prominence, performance, imagery, judgements, sensations and resonance.

Notes

1. https://www.unicef.org/partnerships/hm-and-hm-foundation.
2. https://www.theguardian.com/fashion/2019/feb/08/courting-controversy-from-hms-coolest-monkey-to-guccis-blackface-jumper.

3. https://www.uber.com/blog/new-york-city/give-meaning-to-your-commute-ride-for-a-cause/#:~:text=Follow%20these%20simple%20steps%20to,Ride%20for%20a%20cause!.
4. https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2017/jun/18/uber-travis-kalanick-scandal-pr-disaster-timeline.
5. https://walmart.org/diversity-equity-and-inclusion/centre-for-racial-equity.
6. https://laborrights.org/publications/walmart-effect-child-and-worker-rights-violations-narong-seafood.
7. https://www.burberryplc.com/en/news/corporate/2020/burberry-announces-initiative-to-support-youth-around-the-world-.html.
8. https://www.moodiedavittreport.com/montblanc-signs-off-a-new-charity-initiative-111209/.
9. https://www.red.org/impact.

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No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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